



Bruce Froemming, a fellow umpire and Billy Martin in a '76 World Series tableau.

From the Nebraska State League...

He Is One Scrappy Umpire

By Bill Nelson

It's no easy life, that of an umpire. Even for a guy with a million-dollar heart. Bruce Froemming, the colorful National League umpire who once served as umpire-in-chief of the old Nebraska State League at the tender age of 18, is well aware of that.

After one game in McCook, Neb., years ago, an elderly woman clubbed him over the head with an umbrella, and his car was stoned as he drove out of the parking lot.

Fans boo him regularly. Managers chew him out and players carp at him from the shadows of the dugout.

"That fat slob!" Vern Rapp, then St. Louis Cardinals manager, snorted last summer to a reporter after Froemming's balk call cost the club a game.

There were many tough times in the minors, too. Once, in the Northern League, the man in blue took such a tongue-lashing from the hometown press that he cleared the entire press box—reporters and broadcasters alike. It may have been a first in baseball history.

In the final World Series game in '76, Froemming had an eyeball to eyeball run-in with fiery Yankees manager Billy Martin after giving him the thumb. That probably made Froemming the most hated man in the park, and boos and catcalls rained down on him.

As each summer wears on, Froemming works in swirling clouds of dust—that stings the eyes, muddies the vision, dirties the clothes. And there's the sweltering heat, too, in sweatbox cities like St. Louis and Atlanta.

It's a grueling heat that sometimes leaves an umpire weak and drained, even faint. But not faint of heart—for if there is a quality that major league umpires share, it is inner strength.

Besides strength and stamina, an umpire needs a high tolerance of pain. Even with an under-the-shirt protector, Froemming's chest has been blackened countless times by foul balls. His feet have taken stinging shots, too.

But what of the glamor of travel—seeing new cities every few days, meeting new people, the steady stream of new experiences? Well, the magic of

travel quickly wears off. For most people, umpires included, living out of a suitcase ceases to be fun after a week or two.

The pay, then, must be fabulous. Not really. A rookie umpire in the majors earns \$17,500 and Froemming, as an eight-year veteran in the big leagues, draws a nice but not spectacular \$35,000.

Ask him about his profession, though, and he answers without hesitation: "It's the greatest job in the world. I absolutely love it. I consider myself one of the luckiest guys around."

Froemming is short and paunchy—about 5 foot 8 and 200 pounds—and he looks like an athlete who's gone to seed. No, actually, like a jock who has been living well lately, gained some weight, but who can still handle himself quite well, thank you. He has a round face, straight brown hair and a voice that is mildly hoarse—maybe from those incessant "stiiiiiiiiike!" calls an umpire bellows.

Chatting with him is a delight. He's an extrovert with a sharp sense of humor—a fun loving guy who sets you at ease immediately, someone you like instantly. You soon realize, too, that he's The Hard Way Kid... no silver spoon for him—and you find yourself admiring his pluck.

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"In high school, sports was my whole life," he says. "I'm 38 now and I've been umpiring for 21 years—13 in the minors and the last eight in the majors—but I still remember almost every play in high school. It meant that much to me."

His future as a professional athlete looked bleak. The prime attribute—love of sports—he possessed in abundance, but his 5 foot 8 physique wasn't going to bring baseball or basketball scouts pounding at his door. College looked unlikely, too. His parents were divorced, and money was tight. That pretty well ruled out coaching or the athletic director job he had envisioned.

How about umpiring? When Froemming was 14, a recreation department official had handed him a whisk broom, mask, chest protector and shin guards, and the then skinny kid had tried his hand at umpiring. He liked it—and for reasons beyond the three bucks he pocketed each game.

His grandfather loaned him the money to go to Al Somers Umpire School in Florida, and Froemming—straight out of high school—was off in pursuit of a career.

School went well and he was soon into the fray—an 18-year-old rookie umpiring in the Midwest League. The year was 1958.

"This umpiring friend whom I'd met in Florida had a light plane and we'd fly from town to town. Once, at Paris, Ill., we landed in a grassy field beside a cornfield, using the flag on the barn to bring it in. We wound up renting the farmer's car for a week, so we could get around."

After a few months, he shifted to the Nebraska State League, a rookie league using first year umpires. League officials knew that Froemming already had experience in the Midwest League, so they named him umpire-in-chief.

"The head of the league really did a

double take when he saw me for the first time," Froemming recalls. "I was 5 foot 7, weighed 140 pounds and looked—at the most—15 years old. 'Oh, no. This can't be the guy I've just made umpire-in-chief!' he must have been thinking."

Froemming chuckled.

"Most of the other umpires were eight to 10 years older than I was—and here's this fuzzy cheeked kid—I didn't even shave yet—telling them what to do. Well, it worked out okay; it was a good summer. I got terrific experience. I earned \$250 a month, with an extra \$100 for being umpire-in-chief."

Money wasn't exceedingly abundant in those days. There were times when he'd smother a hotdog with relish and that would be supper.

Times were trying, too, on the field. Players and managers tested the kid umpire. They tried to cajole, hassle and bully him. But the tougher they got, the harder the line Froemming took.

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"I ejected all kinds of people. In fact, the league was wondering about me—they thought I was throwing too many players out of the games. Well, it was a time of testing, and I guess I sometimes overreacted to counteract their aggressiveness. But I wanted them to know that the umpire is supposed to be in charge—and by god, this umpire stayed in charge."

It was at McCook that Froemming ran into his first hornets' nest. Things weren't going well for the locals and the fans were giving the umpires the needle as the crew walked to its car.

"We were giving it right back to them," Froemming recalls, "when all of a sudden this old lady raps me over the head with her umbrella. Well, it didn't hurt much, but it stunned me. Then as we drove out of the lot, our car got stoned. It was a wild and wooly night!"

There were other wild times, too, like a year later in Duluth. One night the pundits in the press box rode the 19-year-old Froemming unmercifully. He warned them to knock it off, but it did little good.

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The next night he overruled another umpire on a close play at second base—a decision that infuriated press box habits. Their squawks and profanities cut through the night air, and the boyish umpire looked up at the press box for a moment, then called time out and shouted: "All of you—out!"

The stunned newsmen—supposedly a neutral force in the game—couldn't believe it. He had no right to eject them, they argued. The hell with Froemming; they wouldn't leave.

But the teenage umpire would not back down. "You've got 10 minutes to clear out of here," he told them, "or the game will be forfeited to St. Cloud."

The minutes ticked by and no one in the press box moved. Finally, after eight minutes, the president of the Duluth club dashed onto the field to make a last ditch plea to Froemming. But the umpire wouldn't budge. Just before the 10 minutes were up, the press corps and their associates filed out—yelling at the ump as they left—and the game went on, without scoreboard or public address system.

The umpires left under police protection.

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